

Previously, on the road to Gearhaven

- The Guardians of Elaria escaped Davy Jones and the cursed ship, making landfall after a brutal night at sea.
 - Floraburst absorbed a drifting ghost-essence and **evolved into Ghostbloom**, its petals turning glass-pale with a star-cold pulse.
 - The quest continues: mend the fractures, safeguard Elaria’s scattered essence, and **reach Gearhaven** for answers—and allies—before the next rift widens.
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Session 6 — Introduction: Lanterns in the Fog

The surf left salt on lips and sand in boots. Morning fog burned to pearl as the Guardians of Elaria followed a narrow path along wind-gnarled pines. Ghostbloom floated at shoulder height, new and strange since the Dutchman—petals translucent, each chime like frost on crystal. Far below, gulls wheeled; ahead, lanterns glowed like a braid of ember-eyes in the mist.

The footpath crested a rise, and the village of Wraithpine pooled in a hollow of slate roofs and cedar eaves. Pumpkins watched from every doorstep. Paper moons and cat-masks swayed over a square of harvest stalls where steam rose from copper kettles and a fiddle found its first notes. The air was cider, beeswax, damp leaves.

As boots crossed under the first lantern arch, a pressure pricked at ears—like a mountain pass without a mountain. A thin note drifted through chimney flues and cellar grates; wind, perhaps, or the tail of a song that refused to end.

(Call for a group Wisdom save, DC 13. On a miss, let a fresh, inconsequential detail slip—just enough to feel wrong. On a success, note the ear-pop and clarity.)

Inside the square, warmth and contradiction mingled. The Gasping Gull threw wide its shutters; a hearth breathed softly. Behind the bar, the keeper wiped a spotless counter and called, “Finally—rush hour! Squeeze in where you can!” The room counted three customers and an old spaniel asleep by the stove. Twelve bowls of stew steamed in the ledger, but two sat cooling on a tray. Keys for every room gleamed on their hooks as if never touched.

“Lantern Night,” the keeper said, already setting a fourth place at a table for three. “Whole village turns out.” A glance at the ledger showed a skipped line—numbers hopping neatly forward, as if something had been neatly erased, or neatly never was.

Across the way, a wax-dusted chandler stacked honey candles into a little pyramid and pressed a sugared chip into a gloved palm. “For remembering,” the greeting went, easy and warm—then a blink, the thought sliding off like rain. “For remembering... well. Black ribbon if you’re heading by the hill.”



Next door, a curio-mender brushed dust from a row of hand-bells and a bundle of old theater playbills tied in twine. One playbill showed a performer line so heavily scrubbed the paper had thinned to lace. “Moths,” the mender muttered, and tied the twine tighter.

Ghostbloom drifted near a lantern. The flame dimmed, then swelled, as if testing harmony with that thin, hidden note. The Essence Sphere gave a heartbeat in the palm—two tones seeking, failing, seeking again.

The square pulled the guardians into its rhythm. A ribboned couple climbed the path toward the hill with flowers and downcast eyes. Along Pumpkin Row, a carver heaved a hay bale toward a waiting cart while two scarecrows watched with button-bright stares. Behind the bar, the keeper sighed toward a trapdoor. “If only someone would scare the pests from the cellar. Ruined a whole pot this morning.”

The trapdoor groaned. Stone steps breathed cool air that smelled of earth and spilled stew. Barrels leaned like dozing oxen. Rats skittered, bold with festival crumbs. Yet something else had been here: under the shelves, a chew-spattered dog collar, and a thin drag across the dust that ended at a seam where the wall seemed to pulse—ever so slightly—in... and out... with the village’s not-quite-silence. From the taproom above came a whistle, then a call. “Dog! Supper!” The whistle hung unanswered.

(If investigated now, the stone holds its breath; the cellar will remember later.)

→ **Quest hook 1: Maera’s Cellar (“pests”)**

Back in the square, the ribboned couple's path beckoned toward the hill. The graveyard leaned under cypress and fog, headstones shouldering one another like men in a cold crowd. Fresh flowers lay on an old plot whose name had been carefully chiseled away—just the ghost of letters left in the stone. A black ribbon around a wrist in the churned earth matched the bands in town; tied with the same neat hands that knotted lanterns. The ground stirred; the recently quiet did not wish to be laid twice.

(Let the dead rise in staggered twos and threes; brisk, eerie.)

→ **Quest hook 2: Lay a Ribbon (graveyard)**

When the guardians returned, lanterns along Pumpkin Row burned lower, carving longer teeth into grinning faces. The carver nudged the hay bale again and grunted thanks for strong arms. The scarecrows were closer now—one step?—straw whispering, burlap creasing to a smile that had not been stitched. Their shadows showed too many joints. The wind died, and for a heartbeat the hidden note was the only sound. Buttons turned. Heads tilted. Straw stepped down.

(Cue the scarecrow dust-up among flickering jack-o'-lanterns.)

→ **Quest hook 3: Scarecrow Stirs (pumpkin row)**

Somewhere between these errands—a cellar that breathed, a grave that forgot its name, a field where straw remembered how to walk—the guardians noticed the old bellkeeper beneath the square's tower. Beeswax glistened in ears. Chalk dusted a slate. Eyes were winter-sharp. The bellkeeper tapped the ear, then the slate, then the notebooks, and wrote three words with a patient hand:

WRITE. DON'T LISTEN.

The bell in the tower gave a single, accidental chime. In the Gasping Gull, a fourth bowl cooled untouched. The keeper set it anyway, smiling at a seat the village could not quite hold in mind.

(From here, you can flow straight into the first quest the party chooses. When enough clues stack, they'll return to the cellar for the reveal—and the path downward.)

Maera's Cellar — Story-first “Rat Rush” (first pass)

Maera slides a key from a hook and lifts the trapdoor behind the bar. A draft climbs the steps—earth-cool, stew-sour, and a hint of tide. “If you’ve stomachs for it,” Maera says, “give ’em a scare. Ruined a whole pot this morning.” The key turns with a clack; the wood groans; the square’s fiddle fades to a thin thread as lantern light spills down narrow stone steps.

Barrels crouch like sleeping oxen. Burlap sacks crowd a low table. A thin line of moisture glitters across the far wall as if the sea breathed here once and left its mark. Somewhere in the dim, a rat chitters... and another answers a half-beat late, like an echo that forgot its place.

Beat 1 — how do you go in?

- **Torch high (bold):** *Read: “The flame leans toward a hairline seam in the far wall, as though the crack is quietly **inhaling**.” (Passive Perception 13 notices this for free.)*
- **Quiet boots (stealth):** *Read: “You hear grain fall inside a sack—like rain—and the echo-chitter comes from inside the wall itself.” (Stealth vs. swarms’ PP10; on success, you can position before the rush.)*
- **Ghostbloom forward (curious):** *Read: “Petals chime; motes tumble toward the seam and drift sideways, tugged by a breath you can’t feel.” (Grant advantage on the next Perception/Insight to clock the seam.)*

Beat 2 — a thing out of place

On the prep table sits a dented stew pot, lid askew, ladle **gnawed** to splinters. A single **black ribbon thread** clings to the rim. *(If someone pockets it, nice foreshadow.)*

Beat 3 — the set-up

- You spot **two shoulder-high casks** on a rack facing a tight aisle; one good shove will roll it downhill. *(One-time STR 12 shove → 1d4 bludgeoning + prone on DEX 12 fail.)*
- A **rickety shelf** groans under jars. *(Action to shove/pull: adjacent creature DEX 13 or restrained beneath broken wood until end of next turn.)*

From above, Maera whistles that two-note dinner call—the sound hangs, unanswered. Below, burlap twitches.

Call for initiative.

Sacks **erupt**. A gray tide hits the floor, claws skittering, eyes catching lantern light in a hundred pinpricks. From the rafters, something heavier drops like a wet rope of fur.

Encounter setup (APL 5 trio → Medium/Hard)

- 2 × **Swarm of Rats** (start one in rafters)
- 4 × **Giant Rats**

Tactics you can narrate:

- Giant rats slip through ankles to mob the frontliner (**Pack Tactics**).
- One swarm scurries up, **drops** onto someone's space (bonus; DC 13 DEX or grappled-by-vermin vibe).



After the dust settles

*Silence returns in pieces: a jar rolls to a stop; a tail twitches and goes still. The lantern's flame, held close to the far wall, **leans inward** toward that hairline seam again—as if stone takes a breath. Somewhere inside the rock, a very faint **humming tone** hangs like a thread. Maera, hearing your boots, calls down, “Any luck? Told you these old cellars touch **caves beneath the town**—wells to the sea, smugglers’ tales. If they’re coming in from there... best come back with stronger light.”*

Pumpkin Row — “The Faces Turn”

Pumpkin Row climbs a low hill between cottages. Hay bales sit two high; jack-o'-lanterns grin from fence posts and windowsills. A carver sets a lantern on a cart. The wind dies. Fog pools like spilled milk.

*The lantern flares—and every carved face along the lane **turns** in the same breath, all of them looking toward the dark peak of the **old theater** roof. Two scarecrows creak down from their posts. Straw whispers across the furrows. Button eyes click in their seams.*

The note in the fog swells, thin and steady, like a bow across a glass rim.

Call for initiative (or give one round to set up if the Guardians study the scene first).

What the Guardians notice immediately (say this plainly)

- **Three big pumpkins**—one on the **north post**, one on the **cart**, one on the **south post**—keep trying to point at the **theater**.
 - Each scarecrow has a **coin-sized gourd charm** sewn under the ribs.
 - Strawlings rustle from the furrows; a **hay cart** could bowl them over, and a **pumpkin stack** could be kicked down to make a mess.
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How to win (three simple paths)

A) Turn the faces (puzzle, very easy)

- **Action:** a Guardian turns or snuffs one **key pumpkin** (no check).
- If **any two** key pumpkins are **not** facing the theater at the same time → all scarecrows **skip their next turn**.
- Do this **twice** (in two rounds) → the magic fizzles; straw collapses and the encounter **ends**.

GM line to remind: “Keep **two faces turned away** and the scarecrows go still. Do it **twice** and the field gives up.”

B) Clip the charm (clean disable)

- **Action within 5 ft.:** snip the scarecrow’s **heart-gourd** (no roll). That scarecrow **falls limp**.

- On a natural 1 (if you like a bit of spice): straw in eyes—**blinded** until your next turn.

Player cue: “That little pumpkin badge is the **off-switch**—snip it.”

C) Fight through (straight combat)

- Cut down scarecrows and strawlings.

Round-to-round color lines (sprinkle)

- *Lantern flames lean; carved mouths click one tooth at a time toward the theater.*
- *Under burlap, stitches bulge around a tiny gourd—threads dyed ash-gray.*
- *A bell pings in the square; the straw stutters, forgetting to move for half a heartbeat.*
- *Ghostbloom’s light dims and chimes—a warning—as buttons swivel.*



Clues & rewards

- Non-violent end or charm-clipping: the carver gifts a **bell-handled lantern** (1 use: advantage on one Investigation in Wraithpine when lit).
- Combat end: a split heart-gourd holds a **PROP ROOM – OLD THEATER** stamp and a map scrap circling **theater** and **well**.

Suggested lineup (level-5 trio)

- **2 Scarecrows + 6 Strawlings.**

If the Guardians lean into options A or B, this becomes quick and cinematic; if they choose C, it’s a solid Medium-Hard skirmish with toys.

Graveyard — “Lay a Ribbon”

Read-aloud

The path climbs the hill behind Wraithpine and levels into a wind-crooked cemetery ringed by cypress. Fog presses low, turning the lanterns’ glow to pale halos. Headstones lean together like old neighbors sharing secrets. On the iron gate, black ribbons hang in neat knots that whisper when the wind passes.

A fresh track of flowers leads to a plot near the crest—earth turned recently, chisel dust still pale on the stone. The name line is a scraped scar. Only the dates remain, and the little carving of a stage mask tucked in a corner like a maker’s mark.

A single bell hangs from a post by the path, the clapper tied with black thread.

If the guardians carry the bell-handled lantern from Pumpkin Row, its blue glass brightens here.

What’s obvious at a glance (say aloud)

- The **name** on the target headstone has been **carefully chiseled away**—fresh dust still in the letters.
 - A **mourning ribbon** rests on the stone, trailing like a bookmark waiting to be tied.
 - The **post bell** can be rung if the clapper thread is untied.
 - Footprints circle the grave, some small, some heavy—**two sets stop, overlap, then smudge away**, as if someone forgot where to stand.
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Three simple ways to succeed

Offer all three; the guardians choose how to proceed.

1. **Restore the name** (*puzzle/skill, little or no combat*)
 - **Action:** rub charcoal over the blank to reveal letter ghosts, then **re-inscribe** with chalk, charcoal, or knife tip.
 - **Checks:** Investigation **DC 12** to see the letter ghosts; Religion or History **DC 12** to place the name at the top like a rite; or any emblem/device the guardians choose to carve.

- **Once the name is restored**, tie the ribbon (see knot below) → the ground **settles**; any undead pause, then sink.

2. **Ring & Ribbon** (*quick rite, may trigger a short fight*)

- Untie the clapper thread and **ring the bell three times**, speaking the name the guardians believe belongs here (or a vow to remember). Then **tie the ribbon** with the **remembrance knot** (below).
- If the name is wrong or unknown, the dead stir: **2 Zombies** rise, then the rite can be retried.

3. **Fight, then lay the ribbon** (*straight combat*)

- Zombies claw up as the ribbon is lifted. Hold the line, then complete the rite once the ground is quiet.

The Remembrance Knot (easy, tactile): make a loop, wrap twice, pull through once more so a small tail points **toward the sea**. Any PC can do this with an **Action**; grant **advantage** to the first one who watched Brynn's tutorial in town.

The disturbance (start the scene)

The bell gives a breath of sound without being touched. The ribbon trembles. From the churned soil, a hand pushes up, ash-pale, clutching a scrap of something stiff—paper? wood? The headstone's scraped line seems to flex, as if trying to remember a shape.

Call for initiative if the guardians start the rite without the name, or if they prod the grave. Otherwise, let a single **Zombie** climb free and shamble until engaged.

Suggested mixes (level-5 trio):

- Quiet rite goes wrong once: **2 Zombies** (easy).
 - Loud, careless start: **3 Zombies + 2 Skeletons** (medium).
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Interactive beats you can read

- *Charcoal fogs the blank line; faint letter bones appear like footprints in frost.*
- *Ring one: the fog shivers. Ring two: the cypress hush. Ring three: the ground answers with a sigh from deep below.*
- *Tie completed, the knot points—a little tail toward the sea. Soil subsides, grubs curl, the stone warms in the palm.*
- *If the knot is wrong, the ribbon loosens by itself and coils like a sleeping snake.*



Ending lines

If the name is restored and ribbon tied:

The knot tightens; the bell's tongue stills. For a breath, the fog pulls back and the grave looks ordinary again—just a stone with a name. Then the name softens at the edges, as if the stone were trying to forget it a second time. But the guardians remember, and the knot holds.

If the guardians win by force and then tie:

The last hand slackens. The ribbon takes the knot and points to sea. The headstone seems lighter. A cypress seed drops and lands where a name should be.

Treasure/boon: Each guardian who took part in the rite gains **1 use of “Hold Fast”**—once this session, **advantage** on a Wisdom save against forgetfulness or the hydra's song. Tuck the **work chit** or pin as the tangible lead toward the Old Theater.

Return to Wraithpine “Names the Stone Won’t Keep”

1) Lantern Lane — Ms. Wicke’s door

*Wraithpine feels thinner on the walk back. The festival bunting still hangs, but the square is nearly empty—stalls shuttered, lanterns pausing on half-breaths, a broom leaning in a doorway as if its owner stepped away mid-sweep and forgot to return. The parcel slip crinkles in the hand: **To HARLAN WICKE — 3 Lantern Lane**. The houses on Lantern Lane press close like people whispering. Pumpkins grin with candles burned down to puddles of wax.*

A brass 3 is screwed to a green door. A thin line of light shows under the threshold, and somewhere inside a kettle ticks as it cools.

Knock.

Ms. Wicke (open the door slowly, voice small but steady):

“Evening. Oh—visitors. Come in, you’ll catch cold.”

The room is neat in the obvious ways and wrong in the quiet ones. On a side table sits a family portrait: a woman with wind-tossed hair and two children in matching scarves; a tall man with a stagehand’s smile and coal on his cuff. Toys sleep in a basket. Children’s books line a shelf—spines worn by small thumbs. A second table holds one cup and one plate, washed and set out to dry. The window shows a street with no one passing.

Ms. Wicke (folds a cloth in her hands):

“I don’t usually—well. What brings you up the lane?”

Show the slip.

Ms. Wicke (reads twice; a tremor):

“Harlan? That’s—” *the mouth shapes the name like a foreign word* “—that’s my last name, Wicke, yes—but I live alone.”

“I wake up, I... make tea, open the curtains. I must have ordered something and forgotten. It happens.”

Her eyes travel, snag on the portrait, skitter away the way a hand skitters off a hot pan.

“I should put that away. It makes the dust look bad.”

Up close, the rims of the eyes are pink; a folded kerchief lies on the sill, damp at the corner.

If asked:

“You’ll think me foolish, but—most mornings I wake up crying and I cannot say why. I wash my face and it stops. Then the day begins.”

“I’m quite all right. Truly. I live alone, you see.”

She looks straight at the family portrait for three slow seconds and does not seem to see it.

The kettle ticks. Somewhere beyond the lane, one long, thin note rides the fog and finds its way along the chimney as if chimneys were flutes.

Ms. Wicke (hands the slip back):

“If you meant to find this Harlan, I’m sorry to disappoint. Perhaps you should try the theater; they keep props there, deliveries and such.”

“You’re kind for coming. Please—be careful at night. The fog keeps... thoughts.”

She closes the door with a gratitude that feels like a bow, and you are in Lantern Lane again with the sound thinned to lace.

2) Bellshadow — the bellkeeper who won’t listen

The square is nearly vacant now. The Witching Wheel is still; the carver’s cart is a silhouette. Under the belltower, an old figure stands in a threadbare coat, slate tucked under one arm, wax glistening in ears the way frost glistens on the last apples. The bell above swings once without sound and rests.

Bellkeeper (muttering to the empty square, not to you):

“Forget, remember, forget. Song like mold. Grows behind the wall.”

“No one else can see it. No one else can see.”

Approach.

Bellkeeper (startled, then peering):

“Mouths moving. Can’t hear you.” *He taps a wad of **beeswax** tucked in his ear.* “Won’t hear it either.”

He fishes a chalk stub, scratches on his slate, then shows the words:

WRITE. DON’T LISTEN.

YOU HEAR THE SONG?

Before an answer, the note swells through the square like a seam opening, like a whistle heard two streets away that you cannot place.

Call for Wisdom saves (DC 13).

- **On a fail:** the festival, the cellar seam, Ms. Wicke’s portrait—each slips from reach like a dream you almost caught. Disinterest lands like a coat: *Why were we standing here? Perhaps it’s time for the inn.*

- **On a success:** a pop behind the eyes, the sense that something important is trying to be smoothed flat.

Bellkeeper (seeing the wobble, urgent; writing fast):

STOP. WAX.

PLUG EARS. REMEMBER.

*He presses small curls of **beeswax** into each palm. The wax smells like summer and smoke.*

Bellkeeper (out loud now, because he pulls one plug half-out; voice grave):

“Put it in. All the way. Don’t be brave about it. The song is not for bravery.”

He reseats his own plug.

*Mouthing, exaggerated so you can read lips: “**UNDER. THEATER.**”*

As the beeswax seats, the world sharpens. The lantern light cuts cleaner. The air feels thicker, like the moment before thunder. Across the square, through the open door of the Gasping Gull, you hear—faint as a thread—the clink of a spoon and a whistle, two notes that mean “supper, friend.”

3) The Gasping Gull — the reveal

*The common room looks the same and wrong at once. Fewer people than there should be. The hearth’s breath a little too shallow. Maera stands behind the bar with a practiced smile and a ledger open to a page that has been written on, and then rewritten on, and then smoothed. A fourth bowl of stew steams at the end of the bar where no one stands. The old spaniel’s **bowl** sits by the stove.*

Maera (bright):

“There you are! Rush hour at last. Sit anywhere.”

She ladles stew, hums a simple tune, sets down a second bowl, then a third.

“Brindle! Supper!” *whistle—two notes, cheerful.*

*With the **beeswax in**, the hum underneath the village does not eat the edges of things. The seam behind the world is open. The Guardians can **see it** now: the way the baseboards lift a fraction of an inch, the way a line of floorboards has been rubbed smooth by something that can’t walk where people walk. The way the spaniel’s bowl has two clean tracks leading from it to the trapdoor—and none back.*

The trapdoor is ajar. The air that rises through it is cold and damp, like stone that has learned to breathe.

Maera (cheerful, not looking at the door):

“Brin-dle! There’s stew, greedy belly! Don’t make me sing for you.”

She laughs without waiting for a response, then huffs to the ledger.

“Four bowls tonight! A record. It’s a wonder, truly.”

*Something moves in the shadow of the trapdoor with a wet, silk sound. Ghostbloom’s petals **chime**; the Essence Sphere thrums frantic in the palm. Then—*

*A long, pale **head** unfolds through the gap like a night-blooming flower turned carnivore, teeth like broken slate. It is eating **Maera’s dog**—already past the shoulders, the old tail thumping once, twice, then not at all. The head does this the way people breathe; calm, as if it had always been there.*

Maera (still smiling at the ledger):

“What a quiet night. Sometimes it’s nice to hear yourself think.”

The head turns. Not toward Maera. Toward you. The eyes are wrong. They aim at the place your thoughts are, not the place your body is.

Call for initiative.

4) Fight — Tavern Reveal (decisive, head destroyed)

Framing (read aloud, short):

The trapdoor yawns. A long, pallid head uncoils into the Gasping Gull, slate-teeth closing on the old spaniel’s bowl with a satisfied clack. With beeswax sealing the song, the truth holds: baseboards lift; floorboards bow; something huge is coiled beneath. The head turns toward you, not your bodies but your thoughts, and the hum in the walls tightens like a wire.

Maera (still smiling, oblivious): “Brindle! Supper! Quiet night, isn’t it?”

Call for initiative.

Environmental toys (quick, punchy)

- Kick the stew pot — DEX 12 or 1d6 fire and disadvantage on next attack (it shakes the taste off).
- Flip the long table — creates half-cover for 1 round; shove (STR 13) to pin the neck (Restrained until end of next turn unless it uses its action to writhe free).

- Drop the lantern rack — rain of glass & flame (DEX 13 or 1d4 slashing; a lit square appears; the head's next attack is at disadvantage from bright light).
- Trapdoor slam — STR 14; head makes DEX 13 or takes 1d6 bludgeoning and is knocked off-balance (no reactions until start of its next turn).

Fight narration beats (sprinkle)

- *Teeth shear a chair leg; it chews as if tasting the name of it.*
- *Ghostbloom flares; the hum drops a note; the room snaps into focus.*
- *Maera hums at the ledger: "Four bowls, a record..."*
- *Floorboards in the far corner flex, as if something else below is bracing to pull away.*

End of the fight (head destroyed)

The head convulses under blade and spell—candy-cane steel cracks slate teeth; emerald fire skates along the neck; Ghostbloom's chime splits the hum. With a final shudder the head goes slack, then tears free at the jaw with a wet pop. Across the room, in the far corner, a second pale neck snaps back beneath a loose plank and retreats into a gaping hole—a four-foot, slime-rimmed tunnel descending into black stone. Cold air rises like cellar breath, threaded with the same thin note.

Maera (blinking at a written "LOOK" on her ledger, breath catching): "Br— ...Where is my...?"
The fog tries to soften her eyes again; she clutches the bar. "Forgive me. I— I'll fetch more bowls."

Blood spatters mark a trail to the tunnel mouth. The hum below is deeper, like a choir trying to sing through the floor. Do you dare to follow?



The Old Theater Below — “Where the Song Lives”

Descent (read-aloud)

The hole in the tavern corner breathes cold. Lantern light slides down stone slick as tongue. The tunnel curls beneath Wraithpine like a rib—wet timber props, black nails, the faint chalk of stage directions scrawled on rock: “Upstage,” “Hold,” “Places.” The hum thickens until it’s not sound but pressure, a hand pressing gently on the inside of the skull.

*The passage opens under the theater: a drowned **orchestra pit** of stone and old wood, crossed by walkways of beam and rope. Stage machines jut like broken ribs. In the center, filling the pit, a pale **bulk** rises from a mound of bones and props, four **long necks** coiled through holes in the floor. The faces are wrong—humanoid and almost featureless, mouths wide with rows of small slate teeth. The bulk feeds through cracks in the town; the cracks end here.*

*Scattered along catwalks and ledges: **boots without owners**; a leather toolbelt with a torn name tag (**HARLAN WICKE**); a child’s carved whistle; theater posters glued to damp stone; a ledger page that reads only... blank lines. At the mound’s base, skulls are stacked with care, each with a ribbon tied round the brow. The ribbons are black.*

If the Guardians approach carefully (**Stealth vs. Passive Perception 14**), grant a **surprise round**. From an elevated catwalk at 60–80 ft., a focused alpha strike can drop **one head** before it closes (as you wanted).

How the lair feels (quick cues to drop)

- *Every few seconds the song “slides” a note, and lantern flame leans with it.*
- *When a head looks away, the bones below shift to make room, as if the mound breathes.*
- *Writing on scraps tries to fade as you read; beeswax keeps the lines sharp.*



Battlefield at a glance

- **Three elevations:** catwalks (10–20 ft. up), broken stage (5 ft.), bone mound (ground).
- **Four neck-ports** in the floor (A–D). Each can extend a head up to **15 ft.** from its hole.
- **Hazards:** rotted beam (DEX 12 or fall 10 ft., 1d6), bone scree (difficult terrain around mound), pulley drop (STR 13 to release for 2d6 bludgeoning in a 10-ft. line).
- **Cover:** prop flats (AC 12, 12 HP); sandbag clusters (half-cover; cut rope to drop for prone).

Running the fight (beats & pacing)

Opening (give the heroes the alpha strike):

If the party entered quietly on high ground, read:

One head rises to taste the air. The song leans. For a heartbeat the theater holds its breath.

Let the team focus fire a **surprise round** at **one head**. If destroyed, drop to **three heads**.

Mid-fight color lines (sprinkle between turns):

- *A ribbon slips from the heap and lands on a boot stamped **PROP ROOM**.*
- *Letters fade on a poster until only the word “REMEMBER” remains, handwritten later in charcoal.*
- *Ghostbloom’s glow pushes the hum back a note; the heads hesitate as if tasting frost.*

Tactics (use sparingly, keep it fun):

Two heads pressure the front line (grapple + reel toward ports); one head hunts the backline; the last harasses from a different port. Use **Bone Shift** to open/close space and a **Hum Surge** to knock out concentration or slow repositioning. The body uses **Regurgitate Remnants** when clustered enemies appear or to reveal a story clue.

When the second head dies:

The song falters, as if someone cut a harmony. The resistance of the flesh thins; steel and spell sink deeper.

When the last head dies:

The body loses weapon resistance; the song collapses to a low moan. Let the body fight two more rounds, then give it a dramatic end.

Resolution (read-aloud)

*Steel parts pale flesh. Green flame runs the grain of bone. The mound collapses like a stage set dropping, and the song finally stops—no fade, just a **click**, like a metronome switched off. Air rushes into the space the note used to fill. Ribbons untie themselves and fall; names flood back into the mind like riverwater breaking a dam.*

*From the tunnels above, voices—bewildered, rising. A bell rings, properly this time: three clean notes. On a ledge, a ledger page finishes its own sentence: **HARLAN WICKE — HOME**. In the drip and quiet, you hear the town remembering.*

Epilogue — The Light Beneath the Earth

As the last echo of the hydra’s dying song fades, silence settles thick as velvet. Ghostbloom’s glow brightens—not a battle light now, but something gentler, pulsing like a heartbeat. From within the mound of bones, a low hum rises again—not of hunger, but of harmony. A seam of golden light cuts through the remains, revealing a half-buried chest bound in vines of silver and root.

Ghostbloom moves first, drawn by unseen will. The air around him shimmers, the ghostly flower on his back bending toward the chest. As the Guardians watch, the vines part and the lid opens—without sound, without resistance.

Inside rest three objects, each radiating faint, familiar magic: a staff etched with constellations, a shimmering crimson sash, and a polished brass core that hums with the same energy as Lilly’s cannon.

Lilly kneels beside the chest, hands trembling.

“...These aren’t ordinary relics. They were made for us.”

She looks to Ursa, eyes wide and glassy with realization.

“It’s Alaria. It has to be. She’s guiding us—testing us. Every step, every battle—she’s making us stronger.”



Ghostbloom lets out a low, melodic tone, and for a heartbeat, the golden light around the chest swirls upward like petals in a breeze—then fades. The chest turns dull and lifeless, its purpose fulfilled.

Return to Wraithpine

When the Guardians emerge from the lair, dawn is breaking. The village of Wraithpine stands silent but wrong. The bells ring and the fog burns away—and with it, the illusion that kept the people calm.

Everywhere, there is grief. People stand in doorways staring at empty spaces where loved ones should be. A man finds a child's toy he doesn't remember carving. A woman kneels at an unmarked grave, sobbing a name that only just returned to her.

The tavern's windows are broken, stew spilled across the floorboards. The barkeep—Maera—meets them with shaking hands.

Maera: "They're calling it a *false hydra*... a creature that eats not just flesh, but memory. All this time... we lived with it, and never knew. My dog, my friends... I didn't even know what I'd lost."

She wipes her eyes and forces a small smile.

"Thank you, Guardians. You freed us—but I don't think we'll ever forget again."

Across the square, the woman from Lantern Lane stands before an empty house, clutching the air where her husband's hand should be. Around her, villagers gather, whispering names and prayers, some collapsing under the weight of what they remember.

Stabby, staring down the lane, grips his candy-cane katana and mutters, "Let's not stick around for this."

Ursa nods, glancing toward the distant hills where the path winds east. "The road to Gearhaven won't walk itself."

And so they go—past the village, past the graves, following the rising sun. The golden light from Ghostbloom's petals fades to a soft, steady glow. The Guardians of Alaria continue their journey—guided, it seems, by something greater than fate.

Scarecrow (Monster Manual)

Medium construct, neutral

AC 11 **HP** 36 (8d8) **Speed** 30 ft.

STR 16 (+3) DEX 12 (+1) CON 11 (+0) INT 10 (+0) WIS 10 (+0) CHA 10 (+0)

Damage Vulnerabilities fire

Damage Resistances bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Condition Immunities charmed, frightened, paralyzed, poisoned

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10 **Languages** understands the languages of its creator but can't speak

CR 1 (200 XP)

Terrifying Glare. One creature the scarecrow can see within 30 ft. must succeed on a **DC 11 Wisdom** save or be **frightened** for 1 minute. Repeat save at end of each turn; success ends the effect.

Actions

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* **9 (2d4+4)** slashing damage.

Strawling (reskinned Needle Blight)

Medium plant, neutral

AC 12 **HP** 11 (2d8+2) **Speed** 30 ft.

STR 12 (+1) DEX 12 (+1) CON 12 (+1) INT 4 (−3) WIS 10 (+0) CHA 3 (−4)

Senses passive Perception 10 **CR** 1/4 (50 XP)

Actions

Straw Lash. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* **4 (1d6+1)** bludgeoning; target must succeed on a **DC 12 Strength** save or be **grappled** (escape DC 12).

Chaff Burst. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 30/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* **6 (2d4)** piercing (described as straw flechettes).

Giant Rat (SRD)

Small beast, unaligned

AC 12 **HP** 7 (2d6) **Speed** 30 ft.

STR 7 (−2) DEX 15 (+2) CON 11 (+0) INT 2 (−4) WIS 10 (+0) CHA 4 (−3)

Skills Perception +2 **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., PP 12 **CR** 1/8 (25 XP)

Keen Smell. Advantage on Perception (smell).

Pack Tactics. Advantage on attacks if an ally is within 5 ft.

Bite. +4 to hit, 5 ft., 4 (1d4+2) piercing.

Swarm of Rats (SRD)

Medium swarm of Tiny beasts, unaligned

AC 10 **HP** 24 (7d8−7) **Speed** 30 ft.

STR 9 (−1) DEX 11 (+0) CON 9 (−1) INT 2 (−4) WIS 10 (+0) CHA 3 (−4)

Resistances bludgeoning, piercing, slashing

Immune (cond.) charmed, frightened, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, prone, restrained, stunned

Senses darkvision 30 ft., PP 10 **CR** 1/4 (50 XP)

Keen Smell. Advantage on Perception (smell).

Swarm. Occupy others' spaces; can't regain HP.

Bites. +2 to hit, reach 0 ft., one creature in space; 7 (2d6) piercing, or 3 (1d6) if at half HP or fewer.

Zombie (SRD, CR 1/4)

AC 8; HP 22 (3d8+9); Speed 20 ft.

STR 13 (+1) DEX 6 (−2) CON 16 (+3) INT 3 (−4) WIS 6 (−2) CHA 5 (−3)

Senses darkvision 60 ft., PP 8

Undead Fortitude. If damage reduces to 0, CON save DC 5 + damage taken (unless radiant/crit) to drop to 1 HP instead.

Slam. +3 to hit, 5 ft., 4 (1d6+1) bludgeoning.

Skeleton (SRD, CR 1/4) — use if the fight escalates

AC 13 (armor scraps); HP 13 (2d8+4); Speed 30 ft.

Shortsword. +4 to hit, 5 ft., 5 (1d6+2) piercing.

Shortbow. +4 to hit, 80/320 ft., 5 (1d6+2) piercing.

False Hydra — Tavern Head

Large aberration (one head/neck), unaligned

AC 14 HP 70 (9d10+18) **Speed** 10 ft., climb 10 ft.

STR 16 (+3) **DEX** 12 (+1) **CON** 14 (+2) **INT** 6 (–2) **WIS** 14 (+2) **CHA** 7 (–2)

Senses blindsight 10 ft., tremorsense 30 ft., darkvision 60 ft.; **PP** 14

Resistances psychic; **Condition Immunities** charmed, frightened, **prone** (it props on the neck)

Mind-Humming Aura. Creatures **without** beeswax that start their turn within 30 ft. make a **DC 13 WIS** save or have **disadvantage** on attack rolls that turn. Creatures with beeswax have **advantage** on the save.

Segmented Neck. The head ignores any effect that would move it or knock it prone unless it chooses to. When it takes **20+ damage in a single turn**, it **recoils 5 ft.** (no OAs) and can't take reactions until the start of its next turn.

Actions

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* **13 (2d8+4) piercing**, and the target is **grappled** (escape **DC 14**). Until the grapple ends, the head can't bite a different target.

Lurch & Drag. If a target is grappled, the head drags it **5 ft.** toward the trapdoor and the target must succeed on a **DC 13 WIS** save or lose a word or thought for a heartbeat (flavor).

Bonus Action

Wrench. A creature the head is grappling must succeed on a **DC 14 STR** save or be **knocked prone** and take **5 (1d6+2) bludgeoning** as the jaw grinds it against the floorboards.

Reactions

Recoil from Flame. When it takes fire damage, the head has **disadvantage** on its next attack before the end of its next turn.

False Hydra (Adult) — Body & Heads (streamlined)

Designed for a level-5 trio with summons and Ghostbloom. It's tough but fair: heads are killable, body is tanky, the song matters, and clever play (beeswax + range) pays off.

Encounter budget: Body + 4 heads (see below). If a surprise alpha deletes one head, run with **3 heads** at start.

Body (central mass)

Huge aberration, unaligned

AC 15 **HP** 130 (12d12+48) **Speed** 10 ft., climb 10 ft.

STR 18 (+4) **DEX** 10 (+0) **CON** 18 (+4) **INT** 7 (-2) **WIS** 14 (+2) **CHA** 8 (-1)

Saves CON +8, WIS +5 **Resistances** psychic; **Immunities (cond.)** charmed, frightened, prone

Senses tremorsense 60 ft., darkvision 60 ft., blindsight 10 ft.; **PP** 12

Song of Unremembering. While **any head** is alive, creatures **without earplugs** that start their turn within 60 ft. must succeed **WIS DC 15** or have **disadvantage** on attack rolls and **can't take reactions** until the start of their next turn. Creatures with beeswax have **advantage** on the save and are not reaction-locked.

Many-Minds. For each head alive, the body has **1 Legendary Action** (max 3/round).

Actions

Thrash. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* **13 (2d8+4) bludgeoning**.

Regurgitate Remnants (Recharge 5–6). Spits out a slurry of bone and cloth in a 15-ft. cone; creatures **DEX DC 14** or take **13 (3d8) necrotic** and are **slowed** (speed -10) until end of next turn. A shattered skull and ribbon clatter free (clue).

Legendary Actions (1 each, at end of others' turns)

- **Hum Surge.** One creature within 60 ft. (no earplugs) makes a **WIS DC 15** save or **loses concentration** (if any) and can move only 10 ft. on its next turn.
- **Bone Shift.** Move the body **5 ft.** and reshape the mound; one 10-ft. square within 20 ft. becomes **difficult terrain** or clears.
- **Coordinate Strike.** One **head** makes a **Snap**.

Vital Link. While at least **1 head** is alive, the body has **resistance to all weapon damage**. Each head destroyed removes **one** instance of this protection; with 0 heads, no resistance.

Head (x4)

Large aberration (extension of the body), unaligned

AC 14 HP 45 (6d10+12) **Speed** 30 ft. (along platforms, tunnels), climb 20 ft.

Reach 15 ft. from its port; can slither to adjacent ports via under-floor tunnels on its turn.

Saves WIS +4 **Resistances** psychic; **Immunities (cond.)** charmed, frightened, prone

Actions

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 15 ft.; *Hit:* **14 (2d10+3) piercing** and **Grappled** (escape **DC 14**). While grappling, the head can't bite a different target.

Reel. A creature grappled by that head must make **STR DC 14** or be pulled **10 ft.** toward the port and knocked **prone**.

Reaction

Snap. When a creature moves within 15 ft., the head makes one **Bite** against that creature.

Head Movement. On its turn, a head may **withdraw** (no OAs), move up to **30 ft.** through tunnels, and re-emerge from any port (A–D). If the party controls elevation and pins a neck (table flip, rope, etc.), require **STR vs. 14** for the head to free itself.

Lair Actions (on initiative count 20, 1/round)

1. **Stage Drop.** A sandbag or pulley cluster crashes; creatures in a 10-ft. line **DEX DC 13** or take **7 (2d6)** bludgeoning and are **knocked prone**.
 2. **Mask of Memory.** A 15-ft. radius becomes **lightly obscured** by paper playbills fluttering like moths; creatures without earplugs make **WIS DC 15** or can't **Target** the body this round (heads are fine).
 3. **Gasping Vent.** A floor grate opens; 10-ft. radius **difficult terrain** and **silencing hiss**—spoken words are muffled; verbal spell components require **CON DC 10** to complete.
-

Staff of Waking Constellations

“The night is not empty,” the old sky-reader whispered. “It is a map that remembers where you’re going—if you carry the right light.”

Appearance & Make

A slim quarterstaff of **midnight-darkheart wood**, banded with **silver inlays** that trace constellations. At the crown, two crescent prongs cradle a thumb-sized **starcystal** that glows when held. Between the constellations are tiny lacquer dots—when tilted, they appear to **drift like a real sky**.

Attunement Feel

When Ursa attunes, cool starlight runs down the forearms; breathing settles into the rhythm of distant tides. On clear nights, the staff hums faintly when pointed toward true north.

How It Acts in Play

- **+1 quarterstaff** (also a **druidic focus**).
- **5 charges** (regain **1d4+1** at dawn):
 - *guiding bolt* (1 charge, 1st) — the crystal flashes, a comet-lance of light.
 - *faerie fire* (1 charge) — pinpricks of starlight cling to foes like dew.
 - *moonbeam* (2 charges, 2nd) — a pale lunar column descends with the scent of cool stone.
- **Starseed.** Once per turn when Ursa deals **radiant** damage with a druid spell, the staff sings and adds **+1d4 radiant**.
- **Starlight. Bonus Action:** the prongs kindle a **soft starlight (10-ft. dim)**. While lit, Ursa has **advantage on Survival checks to navigate at night**.



Alaria's Mark

Set into the butt-cap is a tiny sigil—a **seven-point star wrapped in a leafed vine**. Lilly recognizes the iconography from Glimmerspire marginalia: artifacts **commissioned by Alaria** to “light the chosen path.” The staff’s constellations shift subtly with Ursa’s destiny; one new star brightens after every major victory.

Sash of the Swift Current (Rewoven)

“Don’t fight the river,” the old rigger said, knotting silk to silk. “Learn where it means to go—and get there first.”

Appearance & Make

A length of scarlet stage-silk rewoven with theater rigging thread. Faint runic feathers drift along its length, and tiny brass eyelets catch the light like dewdrops. When tossed in the air, the sash hangs a heartbeat too long, as if water were holding it up.

Attunement Feel

As Stabby ties the knot at his hip, breath falls into a smooth four-count. The world presents paths, not obstacles; rafters, ropes, and even spearpoints seem to invite footfalls. A cool breeze trails his steps indoors.



How It Acts in Play

- AC +1 while worn (stacks with Unarmored Defense).
- Fleetstep. Your walking speed +10 ft.
- Air Dance (1/day). *Bonus Action:* gain a flying speed equal to your walking speed for 1 minute (you don’t fall until the start of your next turn after it ends).
- Feather Fall (1/day). Cast feather fall without components; you must be a target.

Alaria’s Mark

At one end, the hem is stitched with a seven-point star cupped by a pair of wings. Lilly recognizes the threadwork: a Glimmerspire stitch used in blessed safety harnesses—as if a goddess reweave a lifeline into a weapon of grace.

Glimmerspire Pocket Dynamo (Mk II)

“Big wonders belong in small pockets,” said the prop master, clicking the core shut. “The trick is knowing when to let them out.”

Appearance & Make

A **thumb-sized brass-and-crystal sphere**, filigreed with **folding micro-gears** and a tiny iris aperture. The base is stamped **PROP ROOM** in stage-engraver script; when tilted, faint runes strobe like a heartbeat. It’s warm to the touch, as if pre-charged with expectation.

Attunement Feel

When Lilly attunes, the core syncs to her breath—**click-whirr, click-whirr**—and her cannon schematics line up in the mind’s eye like cue cards. Metal smells cleaner; sparks sound musical.

How It Acts in Play

- **Pocket Arsenal.** As a **free action (once on your turn)**, **deploy or recall** your **Eldritch Cannon** from the core (no action to stow/summon; Tiny/Small as normal).
- **Endurance Overhaul.** Your cannon’s **duration becomes 24 hours**; it persists through short rests and ends only if reduced to 0 HP or dismissed.
- **Power Sync.** Your cannon’s attacks/features deal **+2 damage** (their normal type).
- **Reformat (1/long rest).** As an **action**, **reconfigure** the existing cannon’s model (flame / force protector / cannon) without spending a new infusion.



Alaria’s Mark

Inside the aperture, etched on the inner ring, is a **seven-point star wrapped in a leafed vine**—the same sigil found on other gifts along the Guardians’ path. When Ghostbloom is near, the core emits a soft **ghost-green afterglow**, like a stage cue waiting for its moment.